CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

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Automotive Services

Collision Repair · General Auto Repair · Tire & Wheel · Auto Glass · Towing & Roadside · Car Wash & Detailing

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

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BACKGROUND SIGNAL
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

RULE

California chaptered SB 988 on September 27, making windshield shops disclose driver-assistance calibration needs and report results in writing, with civil penalties up to $2,000 per repeat violation.

SB 988, the California Motor Vehicle Glass Act, was chaptered September 27 as Chapter 666 of the Statutes of 2026, and the governor's office announced the signing the same day. The Assembly passed it 78-0 and the Senate 37-0 in late August. Autobody News, citing a Bureau of Automotive Repair presentation, puts the effective date at January 1, 2027. Issue 004 reported the bill as still awaiting action; it had been signed the day before that issue's date.

Before servicing, a covered shop must say whether the vehicle has driver-assistance systems and whether the maker calls for recalibration after windshield work. It must say whether it will calibrate to manufacturer specifications and, if not, send the customer to a dealer or qualified specialist. After a calibration it must tell the customer in writing whether it worked, and warn against relying on the systems if it failed.

Shops must give a good-faith estimate, an updated estimate before work starts, an itemized invoice and a receipt. They may not offer rebates, gift cards or cash to steer a glass claim, and policyholders cannot assign windshield or calibration benefits to a shop; violating contracts signed on or after January 1, 2027 are unenforceable. Insurers may still recommend shops but may not tie payment to one.

The shop duties apply to a shop "primarily engaged in automotive glass replacement." Civil penalties run up to $500 for a first violation and up to $2,000 for each later one, enforceable by city attorneys, county counsel or the attorney general. The Independent Glass Association had asked the industry to tell the governor to veto the bill.

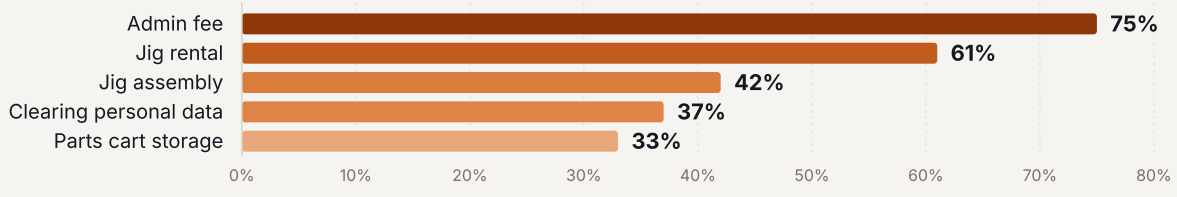
What to do about it: If you do windshield work in California, write your ADAS disclosure script and a written calibration-result form before January 1, 2027, and train whoever quotes jobs. Pull any rebate, gift-card or cash promotion tied to glass claims now, and stop taking assignments of benefits on contracts dated January 1 or later. Decide whether you are "primarily engaged" in glass replacement, because the shop duties apply only to those shops, and get that answer from counsel in writing. Outside California, expect copies: Repairer Driven News says the bill follows the NCOIL model. Ask your state glass association where similar bills are filed, and price the calibration step and extra paperwork into quotes now.

CalMatters Digital Democracy: SB 988 bill record · Autobody News: California enacts Motor Vehicle Glass Act · Repairer Driven News: glass act sent to governor

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / INSURER PAY RATES

Insurers pay total-loss administrative fees three-quarters of the time, but clearing data and parts-cart storage are paid about a third of the time.

Admin fee: paid 75% of the time (base not stated). Other rows: share of shops that negotiate paid always or most of the time. 473 shops, eight insurers, surveyed April 2026; Collision Advice and CRASH Network. Admin fee, data clearing and parts cart from the Autobody News survey article of Oct 12, 2026 (source link); jig rental and jig assembly from the Autobody News jig article of Sept 28, 2026 (autobodynews.com/news/who-pays-for-what-survey-shops-are-paid-to-rent-the-jig-more-often-than-to-assemble-it).



Administrative fees rank first of 21 procedures; clearing personal data ranks 13th and parts-cart storage 14th. Both itemized charges are among the six least-negotiated procedures, and 62% to 63% of shops have never asked. Compare your own billed-versus-paid rate on each line with these bars before you renegotiate with a program insurer. Autobody News: Who Pays for What total-loss survey

COLLISION REPAIR

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

Insurers pay total-loss administrative fees 75% of the time, but 62% of shops have never negotiated for clearing personal data and 63% never for parts-cart storage, a 473-shop survey found.

Why it matters: The Collision Advice and CRASH Network survey (Autobody News, October 12) covers 473 shops in 49 states, surveyed in April, and the eight largest insurers. More than 23% of 2025 claims ended in a total loss, so these charges recur. Among shops that negotiate, clearing personal data is paid 37% of the time and parts-cart storage 33%; 79% of shops itemize total-loss charges and 21% bill a flat fee. This week: pull your last 20 total losses, mark which of the three charges you billed and which were paid, and add the unbilled lines to your estimate template.

Autobody News: Who Pays for What total-loss survey

INSURANCE

Wholesale used-vehicle values fell below year-ago levels for the first time in 2026 while total losses reached a record 23.1% of claims, Autobody News reported October 9.

Why it matters: Cox Automotive's Manheim index (October 7 release) was 205.9 for September, down 0.6% from a year earlier and 1.1% from August, and Cox cut its year-end forecast to about +0.2% from 2% in July. CCC's Crash Course puts the total-loss share at 23.1%. Lower book values pull actual-cash-value offers down, and more estimates end as totals instead of repairs. This week: photograph and document condition and options on every total-loss file, and expect more valuation disputes. Cox's October index is due November 6.

Autobody News: wholesale values below year-ago levels

GENERAL AUTO REPAIR

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

Customs and Border Protection in Norfolk seized 1,818 Chinese-made radiators on September 15, 18 and 22 after the named importers said they never ordered them; the lots carried Reach and CarQuest names.

Why it matters: The three shipments, valued at $206,513, were bound for Los Angeles, Tempe and Loveland, and CBP found inconsistencies in the import paperwork. In late August Norfolk also seized 1,043 radiators declared at $5,775 that CBP valued at $110,176; the two cases total 2,861 radiators worth $316,689. A familiar brand name did not prove origin. This week: ask each parts distributor who the importer of record is on cooling parts, keep the invoices, and question any price far below your usual jobber before you install the part.

Autobody News: CBP seizes 1,818 radiators in Norfolk

REGULATION

NHTSA announced October 6 a negotiated rulemaking to update FMVSS No. 108, its first update to vehicle lighting standards in more than 25 years, with comments and nominations due November 9.

Why it matters: Docket NHTSA-2026-1981 will seat up to 18 members and cover headlamp glare, LEDs, automatic high beams, replaceable light sources, and how headlamp height and aim affect visibility. Nothing changes yet: replacement headlamps must still meet the standard, carry the DOT symbol, and allow aim to be checked by one person with ordinary tools. Autobody News (October 8) does not say which provisions will change. This week: if you sell headlamp restoration, replacement or aiming, tell your trade association what to keep or change before November 9.

Autobody News: NHTSA to update lighting standard

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / THE FLEET MIX SHIFT

Cars up to four years old made 39.3% of driving trips in 2025, up from 34.0%, and calibration lines reached 28.3% of estimates, up from 21.8%.

Percent, prior reading to latest reading (bar spans the two). Trips: AAA Foundation American Driving Survey 2025, 2024 vs 2025. Hybrid sales: Q2 2025 vs Q2 2026. Calibration: CCC, 2024 vs 2025. Autobody News, Oct 5, 2026.



Newer vehicles are more likely to carry recent safety technology, and CCC found calibrations on more estimates. Hybrids are gaining on both trips and new sales, and calibration now rides on more than a quarter of CCC repairable estimates. The AAA daily-mileage change was not statistically significant, and survey answers are self-reported. Budget for calibration and hybrid-service training. Autobody News: AAA driving survey and newer vehicles

TIRE & WHEEL

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

Chrysler is recalling 16,385 model-year 2026 RAM 1500 pickups whose tire pressure monitoring sensors may report incorrect pressure, with dealers notified October 6 and owners around October 27.

Why it matters: NHTSA's report, dated September 29, covers trucks built July 1, 2025 to March 17, 2026 with Sensata sensor 68293199AA, a noncompliance with FMVSS No. 138. It links the fault to a tire and wheel assembly process change and estimates 100% of the trucks are affected. The fix is dealer inspection and if necessary, sensor replacement, so the recall work goes to the dealer. This week: tell counter staff to check the VIN before quoting a TPMS sensor on a 2026 RAM 1500, and send owners to the dealer. This is separate from the Jeep recall in Issue 003.

NHTSA recall report: 2026 RAM 1500 TPMS sensor

MONEY

Producer prices for auto parts, accessories and tires rose 55.6% from June 2021 to June 2026, ahead of vehicle repair and maintenance at 34.4% and personal auto insurance at 24.4%, APCIA reported.

Why it matters: APCIA's September 2026 white paper uses Bureau of Labor Statistics producer price indexes. The parts group includes tires but does not break them out, so read it as direction, not a tire price. Used cars and trucks fell 7.8% on the consumer price index over the same five years. This week: compare your tire and parts price matrix with the oldest supplier invoice you still hold, and reprice any line whose cost has moved more than your markup.

Autobody News: insurer group ties repair costs to ADAS

AUTO GLASS

TWO ITEMS

DEMAND

Calibration lines appeared on 34.7% of repair estimates last year in Enlyte's data, up from 12.1% in 2022, averaging $688 per estimate that includes one; CCC counts 28.3% for 2025.

Why it matters: Both counts come from collision estimating systems, not glass invoices, but they show how often calibration rides on a repair and what it costs. CCC's 28.3% of repairable estimates in 2025 compares with 21.8% the year before. California's new law makes a windshield shop disclose and document the same step. This week: price calibration as its own line on every windshield quote, record pass or fail on the invoice, and compare your charge with the $688 average before a customer does.

Autobody News: insurer group ties repair costs to ADAS · Autobody News: AAA newer vehicles and CCC calibration data

INSURANCE

APCIA says severity of paid vehicle-damage claims rose 42.3% from 2020 through the third quarter of 2025 while frequency rose 1.4%, and ties part of the climb to sensor replacement and recalibration.

Why it matters: The September white paper (Autobody News, October 7) measures property damage liability plus collision from Fast Track data. It says automatic braking is associated with about 50% fewer front-to-rear crashes, but the crashes that remain more often involve sensor replacement and recalibration. APCIA also blames barriers to repair information, tools and parts for higher costs. This week: attach the manufacturer procedure and a pass-or-fail record to every calibration charge you bill, because insurers watching severity will ask for them.

Autobody News: insurer group ties repair costs to ADAS

TOWING & ROADSIDE

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

Florida insurer Star Casualty's class settlement refunds up to $79 in title and tag fees and storage and towing charges deducted from total-loss payouts, capped at $25 a day for eight days, with claims due October 26.

Why it matters: Kharevich v. Star Casualty covers about 2,500 consumers owed title and tag transfer fees and about 1,000 whose towing or storage fees were deducted from actual cash value; Star Casualty denies the allegations. Eligible policies ran March 22, 2018 to June 26, 2026, and storage and towing repayment tops out at $200. Repairer Driven News reported it September 17; the October 26 claim deadline (the page gives no year) is what makes it current. This week: Florida tow and storage yards should keep itemized, dated invoices on every total-loss job so charges can be proven if an insurer or owner disputes them.

Repairer Driven News: Star Casualty storage fee settlement

REGULATION

Arizona SB1366, reported signed by Tow Times on September 25, creates a study committee on public-property towing and impound practices covering rates, fees, insurance requirements and Department of Public Safety towing programs.

Why it matters: The Tow Operators Safety Coalition of Arizona announced the bill passed and was signed, and Tow Times carried the announcement September 25. The committee, with urban and rural operators, will review Department of Public Safety towing programs, operational standards, insurance requirements and rates and fees, and report to the Legislature before the 2027 session. The source gives no signing or effective date. A study is not a rate cap, but its findings will frame next year's bill. This week: Arizona operators on public-property rotation lists should ask the coalition how to submit cost data before the committee drafts findings.

Tow Times: Arizona coalition announces bill passage

CAR WASH & DETAILING

TWO ITEMS

DEMAND

Americans drove 28.6 miles a day in 2025, down from 31.1, and about 2.76 trillion miles in total against 2.95 trillion, the AAA Foundation found, though AAA did not mark the daily change as significant.

Why it matters: Autobody News (October 5) reports the AAA Foundation's American Driving Survey: 2025, released in September, with 5,154 self-reporting respondents. Less driving can cut wash frequency, and membership models live on visits per member. Because AAA did not flag the daily-mileage change as statistically significant, treat it as a watch item, not a trend. This week: pull your own visits per member by month since January, and if the number is slipping, test your plan price against actual use before cancellations show it.

Autobody News: AAA driving survey and newer vehicles

DEMAND

Edmunds put the average monthly payment on financed new-vehicle purchases at $787 in the third quarter, with a record 21.2% of financed purchases at $1,000 or more a month, up from 19.1% a year earlier.

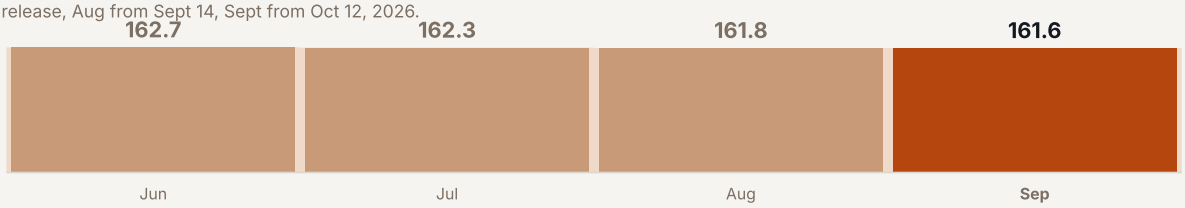
Why it matters: Edmunds' Q3 2026 report (via Repairer Driven News, October 13) shows the average amount financed at $44,664 and 25.5% of new loans at 84 months or longer, up from 21.8% a year ago; the average new-vehicle APR held at 7%. Heavier payments leave less for discretionary monthly bills, wash plans among them. This is a risk signal, not wash data, and no wash operator reported churn tied to it. This week: review cancellations by plan tier since September and keep a lower-priced entry plan available for members who trim spending.

Repairer Driven News: record vehicle financing trends

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / MECHANICAL RATE

The national posted mechanical labor rate has slipped three months in a row to $161.63 an hour, yet remains 12.7% above a year ago.

Average posted mechanical labor rate, dollars per hour, NABR with LaborRateHero via Autobody News. June and July from the Aug 17 release, Aug from Sept 14, Sept from Oct 12, 2026.



These are rates shops post on LaborRateHero, not rates insurers negotiate. The average has drifted down about a dollar since June, but 60% of shops that updated their rates in the past 12 months raised mechanical rates, by an average $15.27, and annual growth of 12.7% was the highest of four categories. Compare your rate with $161.63 before assuming you are keeping pace. Autobody News: Labor Rate Index, September 2026

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

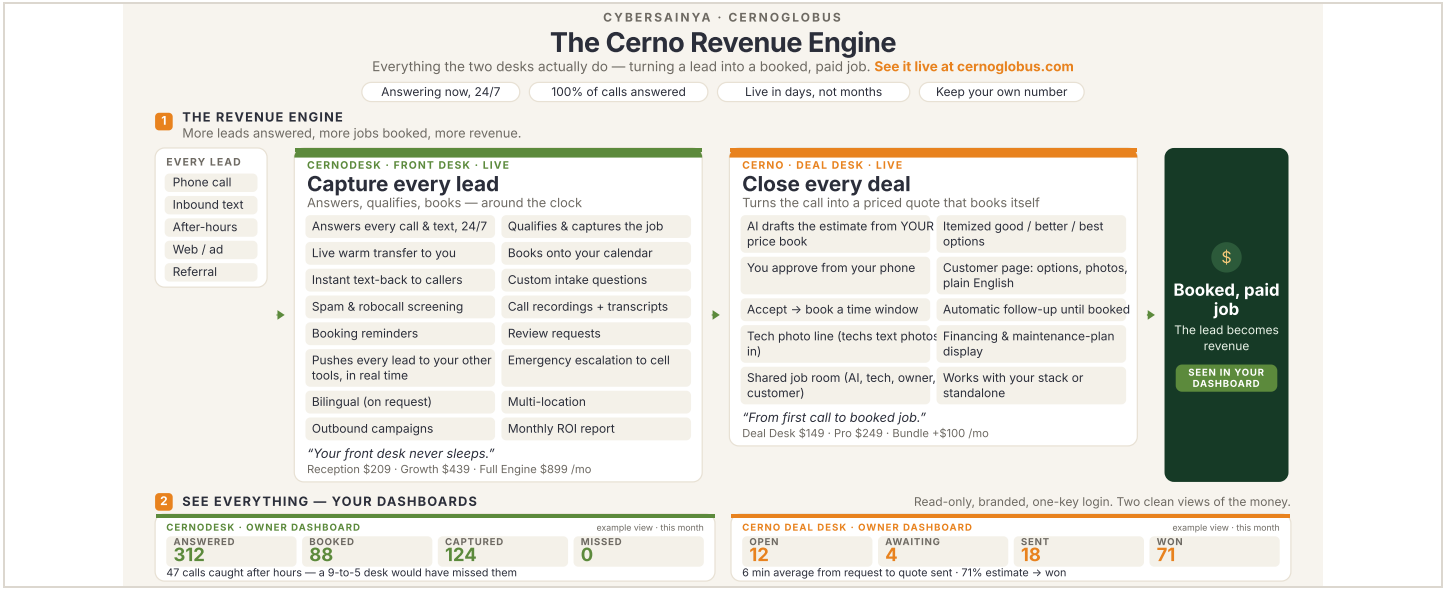
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern a shop owner. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A shop that emails estimates, repair orders and parts invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



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